



As a gift for Francis, Leonardo designed a mechanical lion (the lion was the symbol of Florence) that was able to walk for a few steps before a door opened in its chest. Tucked inside was a fleur-de-lis, the symbol of France.

The gesture may have worked even better than the Medicis had hoped. Francis was so impressed with Leonardo that he invited him to live in France. But it was an invitation, not a command. Leonardo could accept or decline it.



Leonardo pondered what to do. He realized that younger artists, such as Michelangelo and Raphael, were

What is a fleur-de-lis?

It is a stylized drawing of a lily flower that is best known as the traditional symbol of the French monarchy, when it is shown as a golden lily on a blue field. Even today, this is used as a symbol of France.